

5.7 Assessment criteria for technical study

Holistic assessment criterion

Holistic (AO2)		
36–40	Outstanding	Impressive and imaginative in style, ideas and development. Complete (or almost complete) control of compositional methods and techniques used. Sense of musical wholeness — no passage sub-standard.
31–35	Excellent	Convincing throughout in style, ideas and development. Good control of compositional methods and techniques used. Any errors and/or misjudgements are marginal.
26–30	Confident	Convincing for most of the time in style, ideas and development. Some control of (perhaps a rather narrow range of) compositional methods and techniques. Some errors and/or misjudgements, but too few to have a big impact.
21–25	Competent	Generally secure in style and ideas, but development may be limited. Some effective control of (probably a narrow range of) compositional methods and techniques. Some errors and misjudgements, but the piece still has some direction and flow.
16–20	Adequate	A serious attempt but probably some inconsistent/immature handling of style and ideas. Some effective use of (probably a narrow range of) compositional methods and techniques. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems begin to be obtrusive, but much of the piece still holds together.
11–15	Basic	Positive features are fairly few with rather inconsistent/immature handling of style and ideas. Basic use of (perhaps just a few) compositional methods and techniques. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems are obtrusive.
6–10	Limited	Positive features are few. A few encouraging signs, but considerable difficulties — a weak end product in most areas. Perhaps under the required length.
1–5	Poor	Positive features are very few indeed, being heavily outweighed by errors, misjudgements and technical problems. In practice, a mark in the 1–5 band is appropriate only for work which is seriously under the required length or too incomplete to be marked using five detailed criteria.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 1: Chords and keys (Topics 1, 2 (first part)* and 3)

Choice of chords and chord progressions, dissonance treatment, handling of key and modulation(s).

*Criterion 1 will be applied to the first part only of each year's Topic 2 exercise. The extent of the first part will be indicated in the instructions to examiners.

Criterion 1: Chords and keys (Topics 1, 2 (first part) and 3) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Mature and sophisticated use of appropriate harmonic progressions. Very effective handling of key and modulation.
7	Excellent	Very convincing use of appropriate harmonic progressions. Effective use of tonality and modulation.
6	Confident	Convincing use of appropriate harmonic progressions, despite one or two misjudgements or limitations. Generally effective use of tonality and modulation, but with a few minor misjudgements or missed opportunities.
5	Competent	Competent control of harmonic progressions for the most part, despite some technical weaknesses or eccentricities. Sound or generally sound use of tonality and modulation, but with a few errors and/or missed opportunities.
4	Adequate	Some reasonable understanding of the more elementary harmonic progressions, but technical weaknesses are sometimes obtrusive. Some understanding of tonality and modulation, but with errors and missed opportunities.
3	Basic	Some understanding of basic harmonic progressions some of the time, but compromised by fairly frequent uncomfortable moments and misjudgements. Probably little success with tonality and modulation.
2	Limited	Limited understanding and control of harmony and tonality, with many uncomfortable moments and misjudgements.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of harmonic and tonal understanding.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 2: Chords and keys (Topic 2, second part*)

Choice of chords and chord progressions, dissonance treatment, handling of key and modulation(s).

*Criterion 2 will be applied to the second part only of each year's Topic 2 exercise. The extent of the second part will be indicated in the instructions to examiners.

Criterion 2: Chords and keys (Topics 1, 2 (second part) and 3) (A02)		
8	Outstanding	Mature and sophisticated use of appropriate harmonic progressions. Very effective handling of key and modulation.
7	Excellent	Very convincing use of appropriate harmonic progressions. Effective use of tonality and modulation.
6	Confident	Convincing use of appropriate harmonic progressions, despite one or two misjudgements or limitations. Generally effective use of tonality and modulation, but with a few minor misjudgements or missed opportunities.
5	Competent	Competent control of harmonic progressions for the most part, despite some technical weaknesses or eccentricities. Sound or generally sound use of tonality and modulation, but with a few errors and/or missed opportunities.
4	Adequate	Some reasonable understanding of the more elementary harmonic progressions, but technical weaknesses are sometimes obtrusive. Some understanding of tonality and modulation, but with errors and missed opportunities.
3	Basic	Some understanding of basic harmonic progressions some of the time, but compromised by fairly frequent uncomfortable moments and misjudgements. Probably little success with tonality and modulation.
2	Limited	Limited understanding and control of harmony and tonality, with many uncomfortable moments and misjudgements.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of harmonic and tonal understanding.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 3:
Realisation and
addition of figuring
or chord symbols
(Topics 1 and 3)**

The harmonic and melodic implications of figuring or chord symbols, where given, figuring or chord symbols are realised, and where figuring or chord symbols have to be added.

Criterion 3: Realisation and addition of figuring or chord symbols (Topics 1 and 3) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Assured handling throughout of figuring/chord symbols, both where realised and where added.
7	Excellent	Generally very accurate handling of figuring/chord symbols, both where realised and where added.
6	Confident	Generally accurate handling of figuring/chord symbols, both where realised and where added, but with a few minor mistakes and/or one or two misjudgements.
5	Competent	Competent handling of figuring/chord symbols for the most part, despite a few weaknesses or eccentricities.
4	Adequate	Some understanding of figuring/chord symbols most of the time, but with significant weaknesses, and/or omissions.
3	Basic	Some understanding of figuring/chord symbols some of the time, but with fairly frequent uncomfortable moments and misjudgements and/or omissions.
2	Limited	Limited understanding of figuring/chord symbols, but with many uncomfortable moments and misjudgements and with some omissions.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of understanding of figuring/chord symbols.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 4: Sense of line (Topics 1, 2 and 3)

The horizontal organisation of the music: the melodic construction (including any motivic working) and shape.

Criterion 4: Sense of line (Topics 1, 2 and 3)		
8	Outstanding	Distinctive and well-shaped added melodic line(s) throughout.
7	Excellent	Convincing and well-shaped melodic line(s) throughout.
6	Confident	Generally convincing and well-shaped melodic line(s).
5	Competent	Generally successful melodic line(s), but sometimes lacking in shape and/or contrast.
4	Adequate	Reasonably successful melodic line(s), but at times stiff or formulaic.
3	Basic	Some awareness of how to build melodic line(s), but generally stiff and/or formulaic.
2	Limited	Melodic line(s) seriously restricted by lack of shape and/or direction.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of competence in melodic construction.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 5: Part-writing (Topics 1, 2 and 3)

The horizontal organisation of the music: the security of the part writing.

Criterion 5: Part-writing (Topics 1, 2 and 3)		
8	Outstanding	Part-writing efficient and successful throughout.
7	Excellent	Part-writing efficient and successful apart from marginal error(s).
6	Confident	Part-writing successful apart from some minor errors.
5	Competent	Part-writing generally successful, but with a small number of obvious errors.
4	Adequate	Part-writing broadly successful, but with some significant errors.
3	Basic	Part-writing compromised by many errors.
2	Limited	Part-writing seriously compromised by many errors.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of competence in part-writing.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 6: Style
(Topics 1, 2 and 3)**

Stylistic characteristics, idioms, conventions and procedures: use of devices such as imitation and suspensions.

Criterion 6: Style (Topics 1, 2 and 3)		
8	Outstanding	Thorough understanding of style, applied creatively and imaginatively.
7	Excellent	Secure and convincing sense of style, applied successfully throughout.
6	Confident	Generally a good sense of style, but a few minor misjudgements.
5	Competent	Reasonable sense of style, but some misjudgements.
4	Adequate	Some sense of style, but treatment inconsistent or sometimes mismanaged.
3	Basic	Stylistic features fairly few and/or often compromised by technical weakness.
2	Limited	Stylistic features few and/or seriously compromised by technical weakness.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of stylistic features.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	